



THE UNIVERSITY *of* EDINBURGH
Centre for Data, Culture & Society

CDCS TRAINING PROGRAMME

**GETTING STARTED
WITH PYTHON FOR
RESEARCH.**

ARRANGEMENTS FOR THE COURSE



Time	Session 1 Wednesday 24th September	Session 2 Wednesday 1st October	Session 3 Wednesday 8th October
Topic A	Introduction to Noteable and Python	Functions	Collections
Topic B	Conditions and Logic		List Comprehensions

THE TEAM

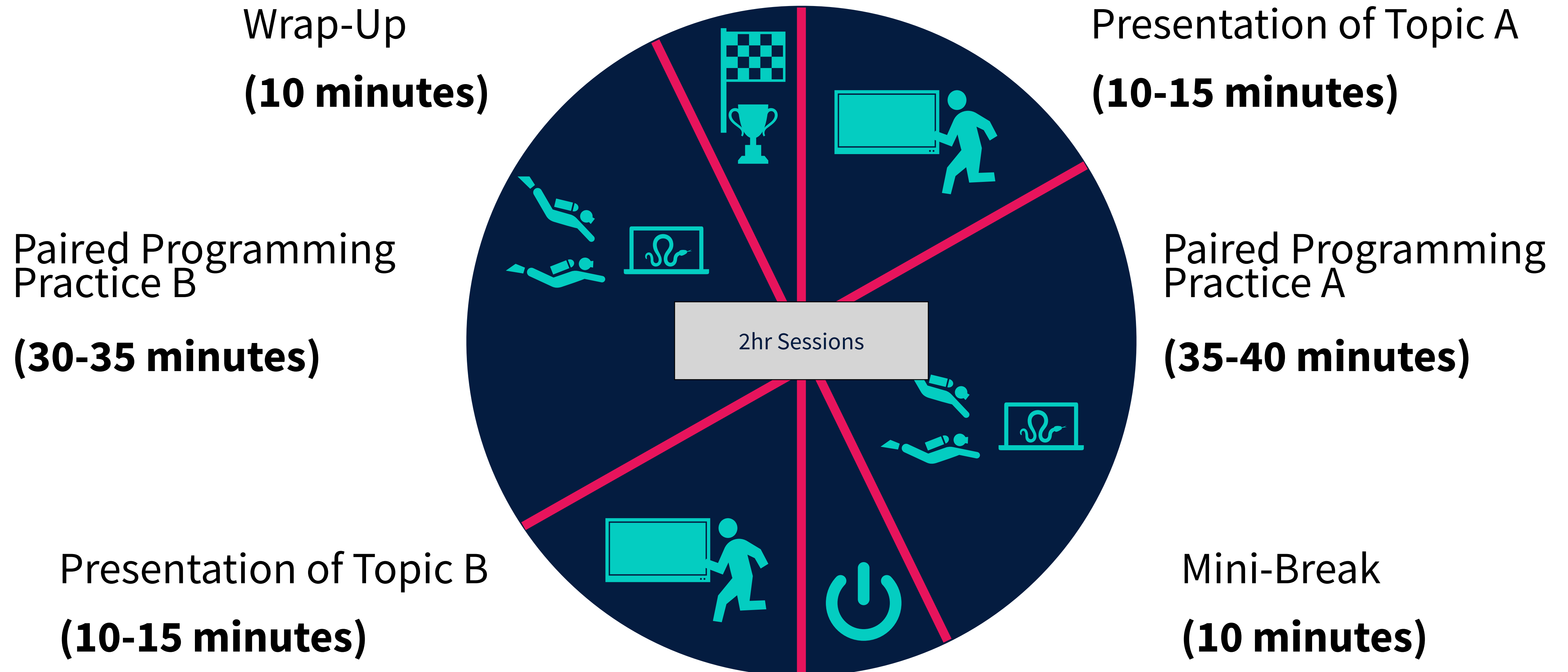
Chris Oldnall



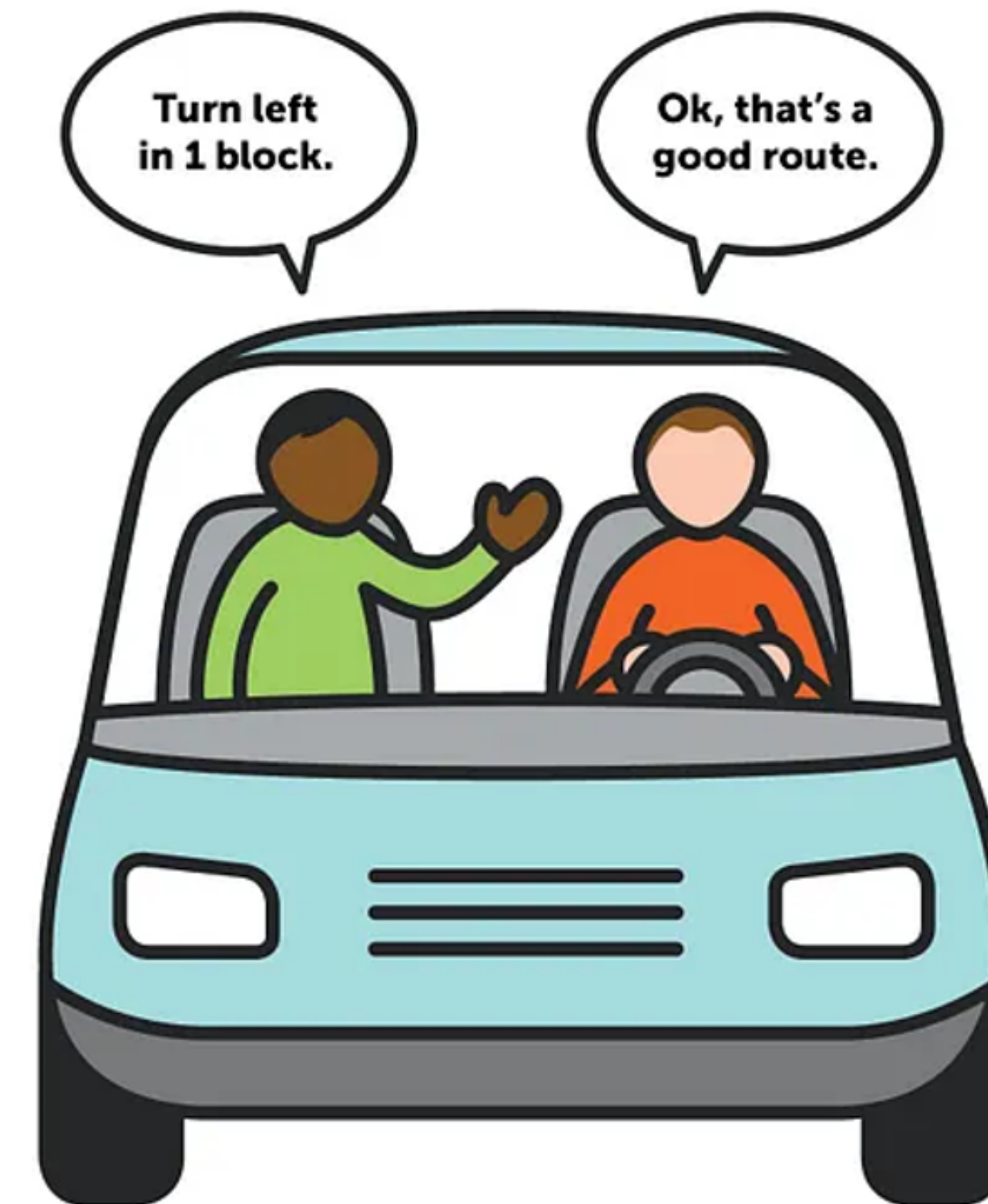
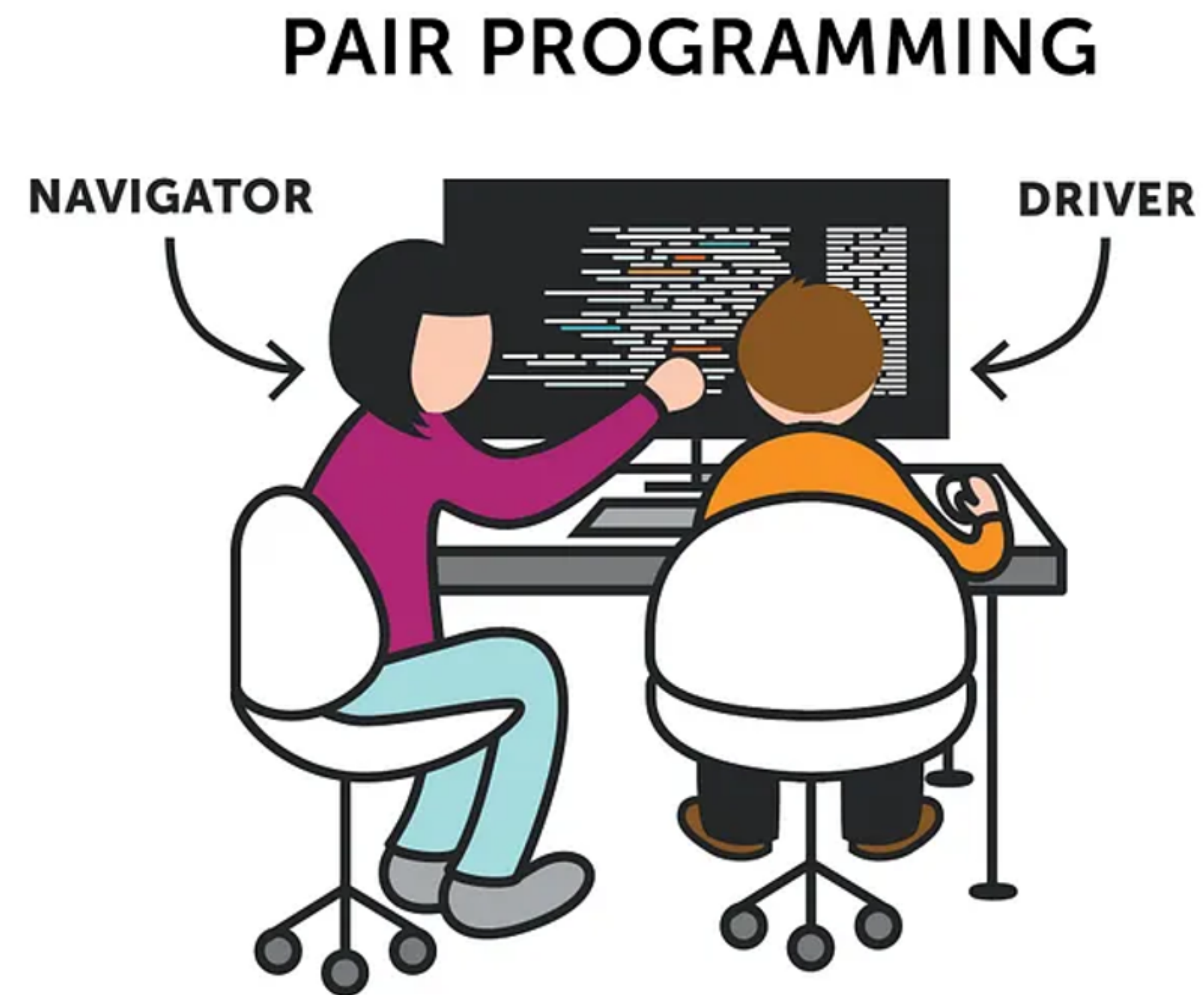
Somya Iqbal



SESSIONS THROUGHOUT THE COURSE



PAIRED PROGRAMMING



OTHER THINGS YOU WILL SEE THROUGHOUT THE COURSE



DEMONSTRATIONS

Sometimes you might see the typewriter symbol. This means we are going to demonstrate something in Python/Noteable.

Bear with us if it takes a moment to switch windows.

```
variable_name = sensible  
print(variable_name)
```

“sensible”

CODE CHUNK TEXT

In the slides we may see text which is ‘pink’ in colour and a different font. This is to indicate it is a chunk of text, written in Python. The colour/font don’t matter just noticing it is code is important!

INTRODUCTION TO NOTEABLE AND PYTHON



Programming = Telling the
computer what to do

You need to speak a language the
computer will understand,

e.g. Python



HOW DO WE 'SPEAK' PYTHON?

In order to 'speak' Python we will need two things...

1. The syntax (equivalent to the grammar of a language),
2. an interpreter (an interface to take in our Python syntax).



SYNTAX

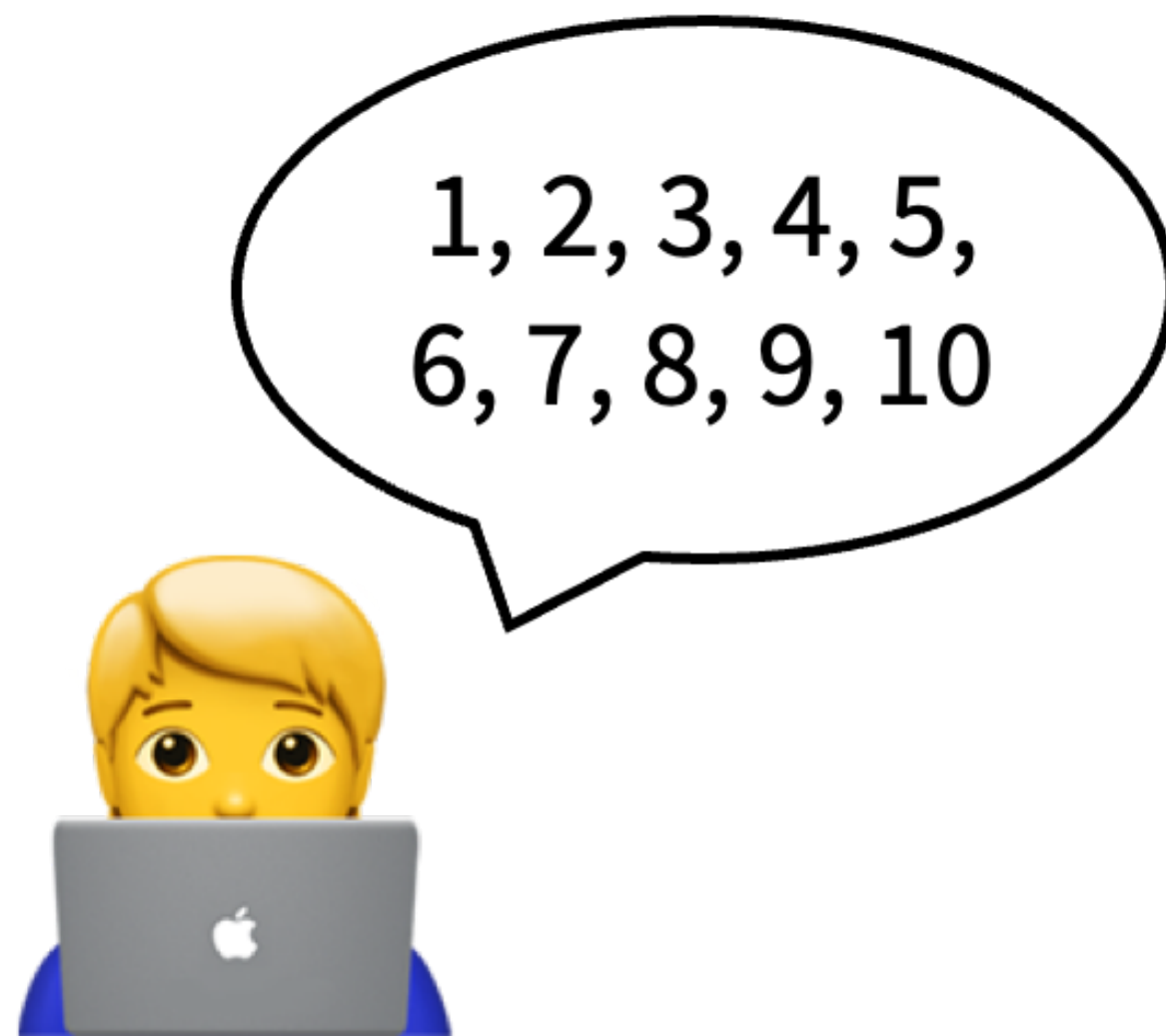
Count from 1 to 10.

```
for number in range(1,11):  
    print(number)
```



THE INTERPRETER

Count from 1 to 10.



```
for number in range(1,11):  
    print(number)
```

```
for number in range(1,11):  
    print(number)
```

```
1  
2  
3  
4  
5  
6  
7  
8  
9  
10
```



JUPYTER NOTEBOOKS

Our choice of interpreter throughout the week will be Jupyter Notebooks. These have many benefits:

1. Easy to use and share with others,
2. can be run on the Noteable service,
3. very hard to break anything (properly).



JUPYTER NOTEBOOKS

jupyter Session 2 - From running to writing Last Checkpoint: Last Thursday at 22:06 (autosaved)

File Edit View Insert Cell Kernel Widgets Help Trusted Python 3 (ipykernel)

Save + Undo Copy Paste Up Down Run Stop Restart Markdown Keyboard Help Dark nbdiff

Memory CPU Disk

```
In [ ]: # Run this code, and you should see the word 'Edinburgh' and 'Meadows' appear below.

city = "Edinburgh"
place = "Meadows"

print("city")
print(city)
print(place)
print(place, "is in", city)
```

The way to understand above example `city = "Edinburgh"` ...

is to see it as `variable_name = variable_value`

- City is the variable's **NAME**
- "Edinburgh" is the variable's **VALUE**
- String is the variable's **TYPE** (String stands for a "String of characters" and is another way to say "text")

NAMES: You can call variables whatever you want, but you cannot use spaces, so use underscore instead, like `student_name`, `annual_total`.

You **ABSOLUTELY** want to avoid names that are meaningless like `x`, `thing`, `foo` or even `result`.

"When you write Good Code – computers can understand what you mean. When the code is Even Better – other humans can understand what you mean. But Great Code is one that you yourself will understand in a few months".

So use good variable names and #comments for your colleagues but also for yourself :)

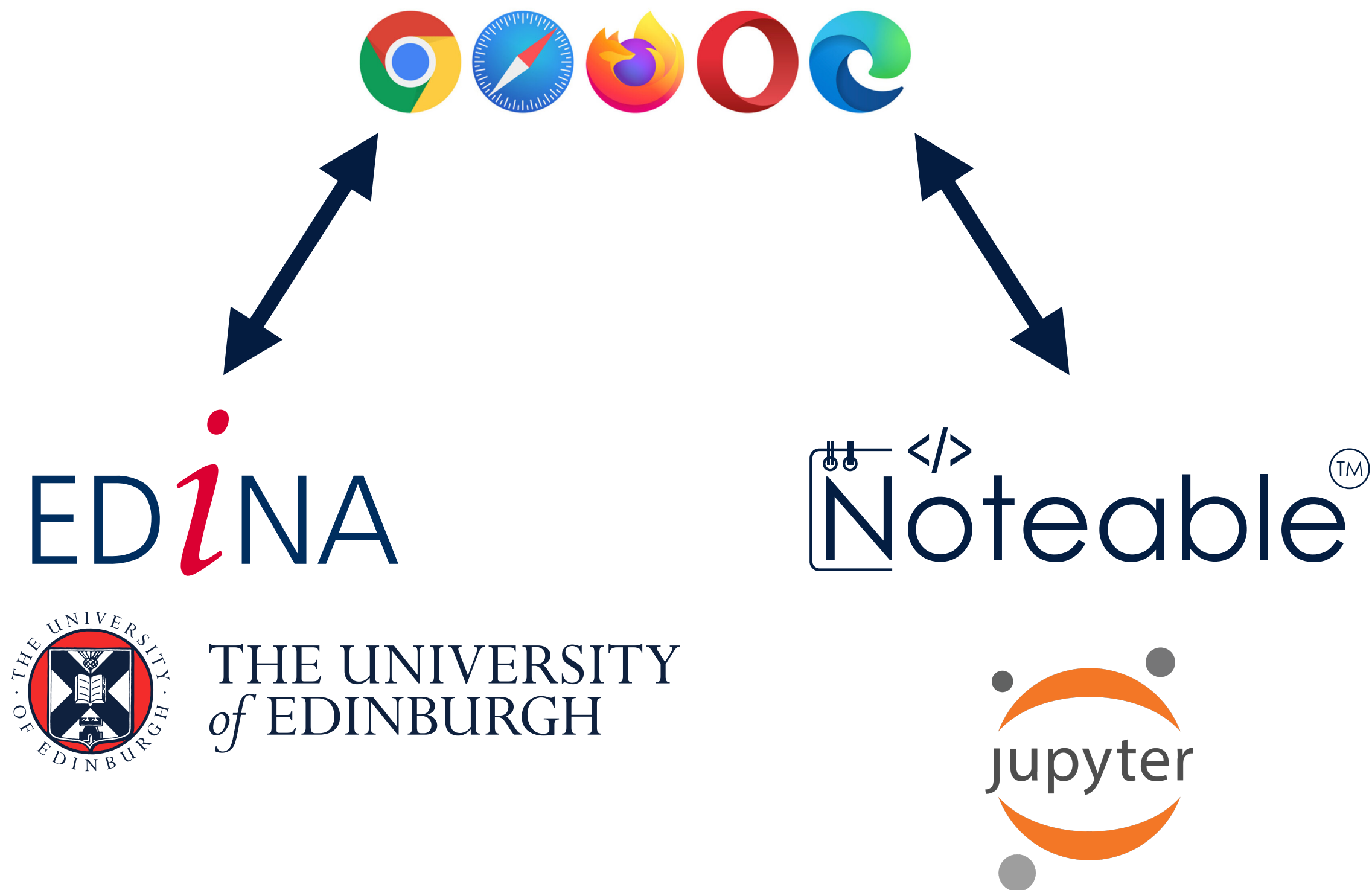
PRINTING variable values: At any point to have a look at what is stored in a variable you can print (show, display) it to the screen.

} Code (Python)

} Text (Markdown)



HOW DOES NOTEABLE COME INTO ALL OF THIS?



Noteable is a university of Edinburgh service which provides online web-based access to a Jupyter Notebook 'server'. As it is not local this makes it great and easy for research and teaching!



TOP TO BOTTOM

Code is written in lines. Each line does something, and they are executed from top to bottom.

```
count = 43  
print(count)
```

```
count = 44  
print(count)
```

```
count = 44  
print(counter)
```

```
count = 44  
print(counter)
```

```
count = count + 1  
print(count)
```



TOP TO BOTTOM

Code is written in lines. Each line does something, and they are executed from top to bottom.

```
count = 43  
print(count)
```

43

```
count = 44  
print(count)
```

44

```
count = 44  
print(counter)
```

ERROR

```
count = 44  
print(count)
```

44

```
count = count + 1  
print(count)
```

45



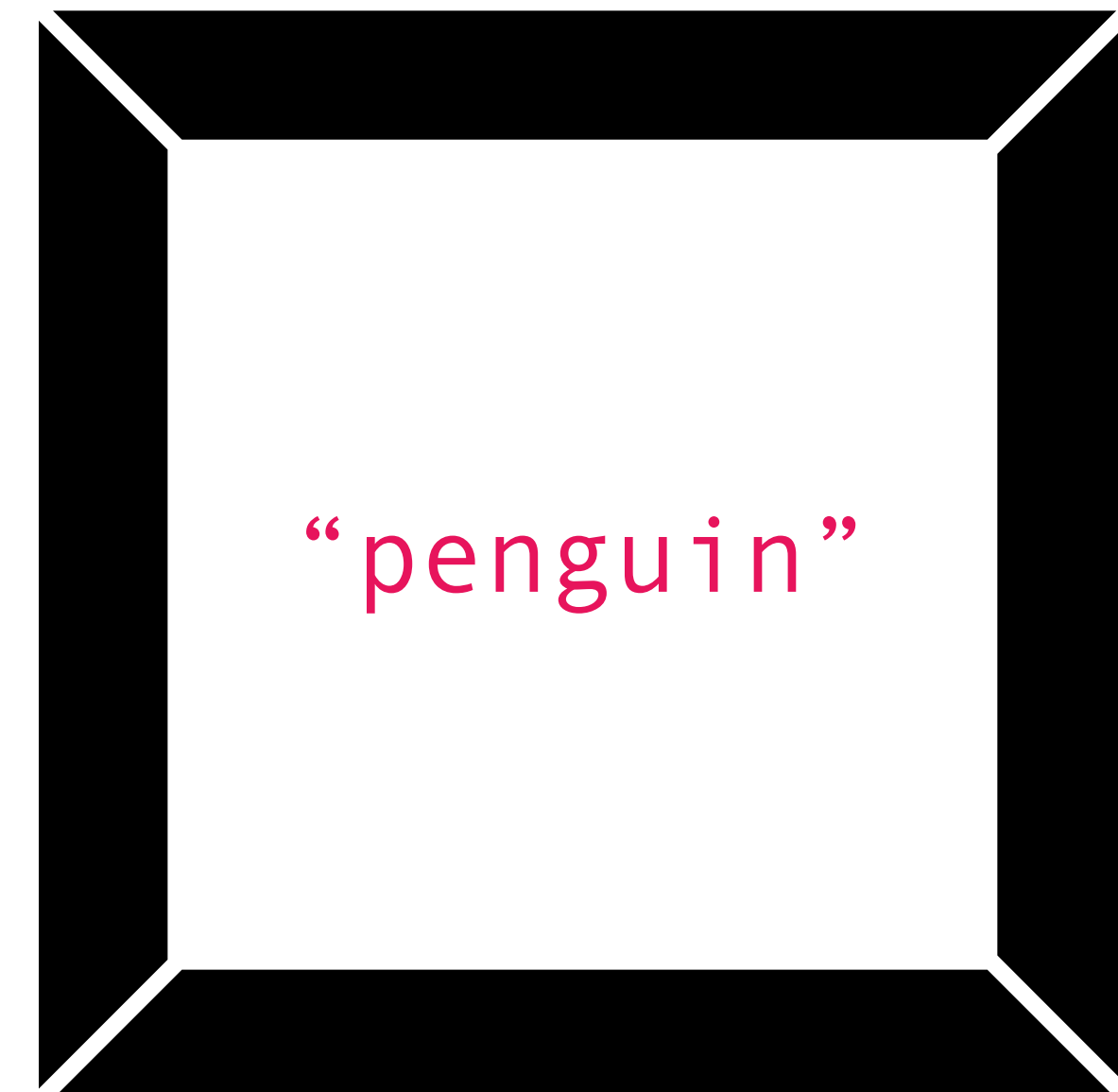
VARIABLES

Variables are places to store values for later.
There are different types of variables:

- **string** for text, e.g. *“penguin”* or *“I like Python”*
- **int** (integer) for whole numbers, e.g. *1, 5, 2014*
- **float** for decimal numbers, e.g. *2.25, 6.1246, 16.2*
- **bool** (Boolean) for logic values: *True, False*

`my_favourite_animal = “penguin”`

`my_favourite_animal`



LETS GET PROGRAMMING

Session 1a: From Running to Writing



CONDITIONS AND LOGIC



COMPARING VARIABLES

2 == 2

2 == 3

"penguin" == "penguin"

"penguin" == "whale"

"penguin" == "Penguin"

"2024" == 2024



COMPARING VARIABLES

2 == 2	True
2 == 3	False

"penguin" == "penguin"	True
"penguin" == "whale"	False
"penguin" == "Penguin"	False

"2024" == 2024	False
----------------	-------



COMPARING VARIABLES

2 < 2
2 < 3
3 > 2
2 <= 2

3 != 2
3 != 3



COMPARING VARIABLES

2 < 2 False

2 < 3 True

3 > 2 True

2 <= 2 True

3 != 2 True

3 != 3 False



CONDITIONALS

Controlling what part of your code gets executed based on some conditions can be very useful in capturing real life conditionals.

E.g. “If the traffic light is green, go, otherwise, wait.”

```
traffic_light = "green"

if traffic_light == "green":
    print('go')
else:
    print('wait')
```

go

```
traffic_light = "red"

if traffic_light == "green":
    print('go')
else:
    print('wait')
```

wait



LETS GET PROGRAMMING

Session 1b: If (This AND That)



FUNCTIONS

PART 1



QUESTIONS TO ASK...

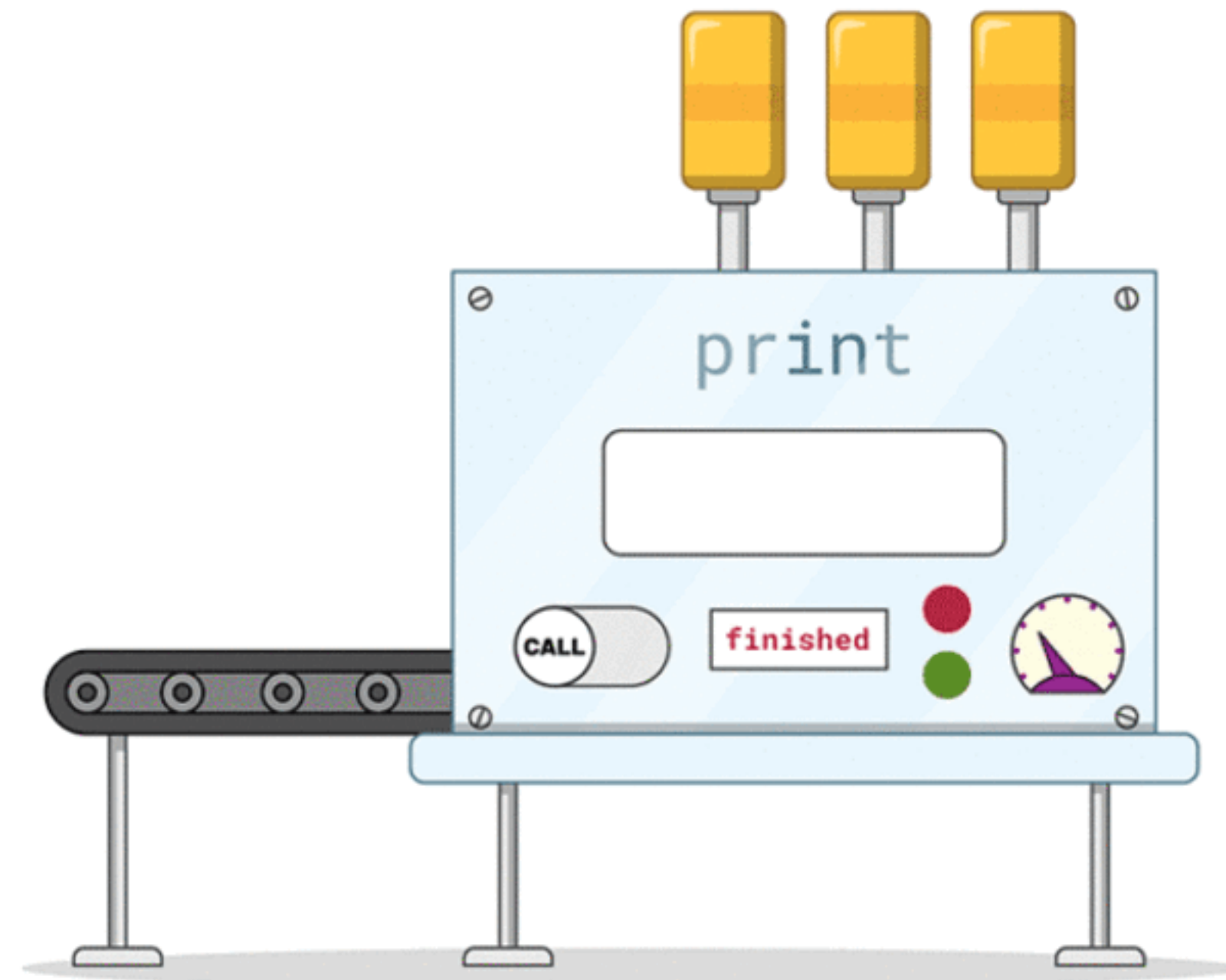
1.What is a function?

2. Why do we use functions?

3. How do I make a function in Python?



WHAT IS A FUNCTION?



WHAT IS A FUNCTION?

A way to generalise a process that will need to be done over and over again.



WHY DO WE USE FUNCTIONS?

- Reduce lines of code,
- Enhance computing performance,
- Make life easier!



WHY DO WE USE FUNCTIONS?



WHAT IS THE RECIPE FOR A FUNCTION IN PYTHON?

1. 'def'
2. Name
3. What goes into it (arguments)
4. What it does (the steps)
5. What it gives back (return value)




```

1 def bake_a_cake(cake_type, cake_size, cake_flavor, cake_filling, cake_frosting):
2     """This function bakes a cake of the specified type, size, flavor, filling, and frosting.
3
4     Args:
5         cake_type: The type of cake to bake, e.g. "chocolate", "vanilla", "red velvet".
6         cake_size: The size of the cake to bake, e.g. "small", "medium", "large".
7         cake_flavor: The flavor of the cake to bake, e.g. "chocolate", "vanilla", "strawberry".
8         cake_filling: The filling for the cake, e.g. "chocolate ganache", "vanilla buttercream", "strawberry jam".
9         cake_frosting: The frosting for the cake, e.g. "chocolate ganache", "vanilla buttercream".
10
11     Returns:
12         A cake of the specified type, size, flavor, filling, and frosting.
13     """
14
15     print(f"Baking a {cake_type} {cake_size} {cake_flavor} cake...")
16
17     # Prepare the cake batter
18     # ...
19
20     # Pour the batter into a cake pan
21     # ...
22
23     # Bake the cake
24     # ...
25
26     # Let the cake cool
27     # ...
28
29     # Fill the cake if specified
30     if cake_filling:
31         # Fill the cake
32         # ...
33
34     # Frost the cake if specified
35     if cake_frosting:
36         # Frost the cake
37         # ...
38
39     print("Cake is ready!")
40     return f"{cake_type} {cake_size} {cake_flavor} cake with {cake_filling} and {cake_frosting}"

```



LETS GET PROGRAMMING

Session 2a: Write the Recipe



FUNCTIONS

PART 2



LOCAL AND GLOBAL



Local:

Only those close to him (*within the same function*) who know about what he can do.



Global:

Can be accessed by anyone, anywhere – everyone knows what he can do!



THE SCOPE RULES

Rule 1: Anything inside a function is mysterious to the outside...

You are not able to peek inside of a function elsewhere in code.
Only things returned will become available to the 'global' environment.

Rule 2: Functions can look outside, but shouldn't...

Things can get complicated when a function looks outside.
We tackle this by carefully specifying arguments with relevant names.



LETS GET PROGRAMMING

Session 2b: SCOPE



COLLECTIONS



LISTS

```
planet0 = "Mercury"  
planet1 = "Venus"  
planet2 = "Earth"  
planet3 = "Mars"  
planet4 = "Jupyter"  
planet5 = "Saturn"  
planet6 = "Uranus"
```



LISTS

```
planet0 = "Mercury"  
planet1 = "Venus"  
planet2 = "Earth"  
planet3 = "Mars"  
planet4 = "Jupyter"  
planet5 = "Saturn"  
planet6 = "Uranus"
```

```
planets = ["Mercury", "Venus", "Earth",  
           "Mars", "Jupyter", "Saturn", "Uranus"]
```



WHY USE LISTS?

```
planets = ["Mercury", "Venus", "Earth", "Mars",  
"Jupyter", "Saturn", "Uranus"]
```

- ✓ Count how many items are in the list
- ✓ Check if a specific item is in the list
- ✓ Find the location of a specific item
- ✓ Add and remove items
- ✓ Sort (alphabetically or otherwise)



Pluto (not a planet)



ALTERNATIVES TO LISTS

Tuple

```
planets = ("Mercury", "Venus", "Earth", "Mars",  
"Jupyter", "Saturn", "Uranus")
```

- Uses () instead of []
- Same as a list, except it cannot be changed after creating it



ALTERNATIVES TO LISTS

Set

```
planets = {"Mercury", "Venus", "Earth", "Mars",  
"Jupyter", "Saturn", "Uranus"}
```

- Uses {} instead of [] (list) or () (tuple)
- Same as a list, except:
 - Every item is unique (items cannot be listed twice)
 - Order does not matter and will change (no indexing)



ALTERNATIVES TO LISTS

Dictionaries

- Used to store multiple pieces of information about one thing
- Uses key-value pairs: each piece of data (value) has a label (key)

```
mercury = {"name": "Mercury", "day_length": 59, "hottest_temp": 430}
```



ALTERNATIVES TO LISTS

Dictionaries and Lists Together

- Combining lists and dictionaries is useful for real-world data: We often have multiple pieces of information about lots of different things and want to work with all of it at the same time!

```
planets = [  
    {"name": "Mercury", "day_length": 59, "hottest_temp": 430},  
    {"name": "Venus", "day_length": 243.025, "hottest_temp": 462},  
    {"name": "Earth", "day_length": 1, "hottest_temp": 56.7},  
    ...  
]
```



LETS GET PROGRAMMING

Session 3a: [{collections}]



LIST COMPREHENSIONS



WHAT ARE LIST COMPREHENSIONS



How do I get someone to pick the shirts from the wardrobe?

1. Say that it is the shirts you want,
2. For each item of clothing, check if it is a shirt,
3. If it's a shirt, then take it out the wardrobe.




```
shirts = [  
    item_of_clothing  
    for item in wardrobe  
    if item == shirt  
]
```



```
initial_list = [thing1, thing2, ...]  
variable_name = [  
    <thing to get new list of>  
    for item in initial_list  
    if item == /> /< <some condition>  
]
```



**Some maths functions
that may come in
handy...**



`max( ) / min( )`

Get the largest/smallest element in a group. For letters it will mean 'highest/lowest in the alphabet'.

`len( )`

Size of the collection, can be used on lists, dicts, but also on strings.

`sum( )`

Combine all elements. Just used for numbers.



LETS GET PROGRAMMING

Session 3b: Lists of Lists



FINISHING UP



How to import data

To import data there is a range of methods, the easiest is using the package 'pandas'

Eg.

```
import pandas as pd  
data_frame = pd.read_csv("<Your File Pathway>")
```



Additional Resources

- This course used (slightly modified) notebooks from Code Storytelling (<http://www.codestorytelling.com>). We covered badges 1,2,4,5,7, and 8. Consider working through some more of the notebooks and watching some of the videos.
- Think Python is an introductory Python book with many exercises, free to read online: <https://greenteapress.com/wp/think-python-2e/>



Feedback for us...

- We hope you've enjoyed the course as much as we did.
- It is really useful for us to hear your feedback

<https://forms.office.com/r/YYNrqvUNr8>

Should be really quick and only take 5 mins (maximum!)



- Getting Started with Descriptive Statistics
(8th December 2025, with Chris Oldnall)
- Using APIs for research
(26 Nov 2025 and 3 Dec 2025, with Somya Iqbal)

